

Roman baths

Roman houses had water supplied via lead pipes, but as water supply was taxed, public baths, or *thermae*, evolved. These took on monumental proportions, with colonnades, arches and domes, statues and mosaics. Features included the *apodyterium* (changing rooms), *palaestrae* (exercise rooms), *notatio* (open-air swimming pool), *laconica* and *sudatoria* (heated dry and wet sweating-rooms), the *caldarium*, *tepidarium* and *frigidarium* (hot, warm and cool rooms), and chambers for massage and other treatments, toilets, libraries and a range of other facilities.

Early baths were heated by braziers, later using the hypocaust system, in which wood-burning furnaces sent warm air under a raised floor. The introduction of glass windows from the first century CE improved temperature control. Water was supplied by purpose-built aqueducts and regulated by huge internal reservoirs. Notable examples include the Baths of Caracalla and Diocletian in Rome (c.215 and c.305 CE respectively), and the complex in Bath in England (second century CE, opposite).

